



HUNTERS AND HUNTED

Small aquatic animals such as insects are eaten by fish and frogs, which are preyed upon by larger fish, and diving birds such as cormorants and grebes. The large fish are targeted by powerful hunters—herons, fish eagles, crocodiles, river dolphins, otters like this one, and even grizzly bears, which wade into Alaskan rivers to catch salmon.

FAST FACTS

- The freshwater lakes with the least life are not those with no nutrients, but the ones with too many.
- The microbes that live in hot springs can survive temperatures of 176°F (80°C) or more.
- Some animals can survive for months in dried mud and breed in the pools that form after heavy rain.

FLOWING WATER

Fast-flowing water causes problems for freshwater life. Drifting plankton cannot survive, which means that there is little food. Despite this, some small animals cling to rocks or streambeds, providing prey for other animals. Fish such as these salmon deliberately swim upstream to breed in these waters, partly because there are fewer predators.



LIVING WITH EXTREMES

Some lakes are not really freshwater habitats at all because they are full of dissolved salt or soda. This makes them hostile to many forms of life. However, a few organisms have evolved ways of surviving. These include the microscopic algae called spirulina that flourish in the soda lakes of the African Rift Valley, and are sifted from the chemical-rich water by flocks of lesser flamingos.

